THERE IS A FEAR AMONG STATE CONGRESS LEADERS THAT IF RAHUL GANDHI EXITS, IT WILL AFFECT THE FORTUNES OF THE PARTY

state secretary who broke with the party after tangling with party general secretary P.K. Kunhalikutty.

As for the Congress, a senior leader told INDIA TODAY, "All our candidates except for Rahul have started their poll campaign. We will announce our list after he decides.... We want him to contest from Wayanad. But there is pressure from the I.N.D.I.A. front as he'll have to fight Annie Raja." There are rumours that AICC general secretary K.C. Venugopal may replace Rahul in the UDF stronghold. But local leaders are none too happy with that news.

Many state leaders feel that if Rahul exits, it'll affect the party's fortunes all over the state. One of them was open about the crisis in the state unit: "Frankly speaking, we are caught between the devil (CM Pinarayi Vijayan) and the deep sea (PM Narendra Modi). The BJP has not opened its account in Kerala, but defeat in a majority of the constituencies could lead to an exodus of leaders and cadre to the BJP."

The saffron party is pinning its hopes on the Thrissur and Thiruvananthapuram LS seats, where they had run the big two close in 2019. They too have not announced their candidates, playing a waiting game with the Congress. Kerala is the outlier in the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's plans and they are keen to break ground here. The PM has visited the state thrice in the past two months, addressed the cadre and leaders and also inaugurated a host of projects. The party wanted to field popular actress and classical dancer Shobana from Thiruvananthapuram, her home town, and even approached her through superstar Suresh Gopi, the likely candidate for Thrissur. Gopi also confirmed this to the media, but Congress MP Shashi Tharoor, who has represented the state capital since 2009, says he's sure she won't contest for the BJP. ■



THE NEW CUSTODIAN Patwari (centre) takes stock of preparations for the Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra in Morena, Feb. 27

MADHYA PRADESH/CONGRESS

Patwari Plots a Revival

By Rahul Noronha

The walls of Jitendra 'Jitu' Patwari's office at his 74 Bungalows residence in Bhopal are covered with photos of the Congress pantheon. But two portraits—that of former Madhya Pradesh chief ministers Kamal Nath, 77, and Digvijaya Singh, 76—stand out, literally framing one of the key issues Patwari faces now. That is, how to work out a seamless transition from the old guard, represented by those two, to the new, of which he is the motif.

Patwari, 50, who took over the reins of the state Congress from Kamal Nath in mid-December, a fortnight after the party failed miserably in dislodging the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the assembly election, faces a trial by fire. There is the Lok Sabha election looming ahead, and the attrition in the Congress's ranks—real and potential—is only making his job tougher.

While no one is willing to admit it on record, the Congress leadership has decided not to